

FIELD OF VISION | SHARDA UGRA

The Doctor in Delhi



The news of him showing up at the Yamaha pavilion in Delhi's ever-chaotic Auto Expo seemed to triple a 500-capacity space. Outside an entrance squeezed shut, hundreds more were waiting. The clueless may have thought a Bollywood star was due but most waited breathlessly for their first sighting of the Italian called *Il Dottore*. The Doctor.

It's not precisely clear why Valentino Rossi, the greatest motorbike racer in history is addressed by that name. Maybe because he can sense the pulse of a crowd like he did in Delhi, ready to lean forward to shake a thousand hands. Security had to hold him back because they certainly wouldn't have been able to hold a larger number back from him.

Never mind his famous predecessors and their considerable achievements. It is Rossi who has thrown motorbike racing and the brand of MotoGP, often called F1 on two wheels, into a wider world. He has won 103 races, nine world titles in four classes and is MotoGP (800 cc) world champion. Yet, that is not his only appeal. It happens to be more personal.

The bike that won two 2009 MotoGP world championships, the Yamaha YZR-M1, weighs 148 kg and growls out speeds over 320 kmph. The man who turned it into an emissary of his ability looks like a Raffaello cherub grown into a 5-ft10-in skinny imp.

Surrounded by Yamaha's big suits (and a few big leathers) at a media meeting in Delhi, Rossi, 31, asked for coffee, pushed away a plate of cookies and was at ease

to speak and be spoken to. Many meeting him for the first time addressed him as "Vale", the way

his friends do. For an hour, he proved that while racing on a souped-up bike may look like a mix of testosterone and glamour, the genuine Vale cocktail was spiked with sweat and served in a cup of joy.

This is the man who crouches in front of his bike before a race to "make a link" with the machine. Who plans victory celebrations with his fan club and helmet designer (and once used a Portaloo in the middle of a victory lap).

Who scouts all rivals not just in MotoGP, but in the 125 cc and 250 cc because the new contender could come from anywhere. Who can tell which rival likes to 'fight' with a scrape of metal and an exchange of exhaust smoke and which one likes to stay away. Who runs miles to stay strong from the first lap to the 42nd. Who doesn't crash often but dealt with short-term memory loss when he once did. Who held up his hand to show a crooked little digit. "This is a motorcycle rider's finger," he grinned and the sun almost broke through Delhi's slate grey skies.

He had watched the crazy bikers weaving their way through Indian traffic and said he wouldn't mind trying it out on one of his sponsor's new bikes. But to every dreamer on two wheels, Rossi had a reminder of the difference between the road and track: "A lot of things happen on the street. But the track is another planet." Where wheelies can be done in third gear. By Doctors.



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

ROSSI'S APPEAL IS NOT JUST RACING BIKES, IT HAPPENS TO BE MORE PERSONAL. IN DELHI, THE GENUINE 'VALE' COCKTAIL WAS SERVED IN A CUP OF JOY.

SIGNPOSTS

SELECTED: Rukhsana Kauser, 22, for the President's newly instituted bravery award, Sarvottam Jeevan Raksha Padak, for fighting



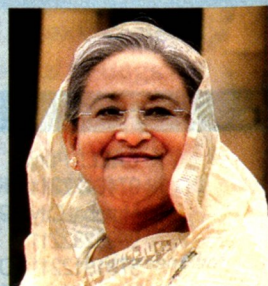
AFP

off two Lashkar-e-Toiba militants and killing one of them at Kalsian village in J&K last year.

DIED: Dewan Singh Jagdish, 96, the first MLA to be elected from Ludhiana. He was a former president of the District Congress Committee and president of Freedom Fighters' Organisation of India.

APPOINTED: Ajit Rangnekar as the dean of the Indian School of Business (ISB). He has worked with the consulting industry for 30 years and was the deputy dean of ISB.

CONFERRED: On Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, the Indira Gandhi Prize for Peace, Disarmament and Development.



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